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The Almonte Gazette



Vol. 2, 131st Year

January 8, 1997

93° + 7° GST



Uphill battle

Young Peter Lowe, 6, looks like he'd rather be headed in the other direction as he struggles to get his snow racer up the hill at Gemmill Park Friday. Hundreds of children, young and old alike, took ad-

vantage of the ideal conditions to go for a slide in the park last week.
Photo by Ryland Coyne

Family learns of community spirit after house fire

By Gena Gibson
Gazette reporter

Out of tragedy comes a sense of community.

When their house burned down Dec. 29, Julie and Stuart Yeaman and their sons had many places to turn. As with many local tragedies, friends and others joined forces to make the situation as easy as possible for the Yeamans.

"There's lots of good that comes along with the bad," Yeaman said from Almonte and District High School on her first day back at work. "It organizes your priorities and values."

"The most important thing is people."

Within a day of the Yeamans' house burning down outside Blakeney, friends had organized drop-off points for donations, as well as bank accounts to aid the family. The Hub on Almonte's main street took in small donations, with Penny Blades accepting larger donations.

Blades said people have phoned and offered a television, a bed, chairs, tables and a bookcase, among other items.

"With the television, somebody drove up from Ottawa," she said. "They had heard about it on the radio or in the newspaper."

Marianne Smith is the Yeamans' neighbour, and she helped organize the fund-raising efforts. She said the family still needs all the necessities, and would also like two pairs of wooden cross country skis.

Mount Pakenham donated ski rentals for five days for the three boys, Sam, Alex and Theo. Yeaman also belongs to a food co-op, and plans have been made to give the family the food Yeaman had ordered.

"That's a very big deal to me," she said. "I really count on that kind of stuff."

John Bolton, who has done work

for the Yeamans, started a raffle with two \$50 prizes. He also hoped to organize a fund-raising card game and pool tournament with proceeds going to the family.

Ingrid Hamster, president of The Hub in Almonte, took in clothing and other donations for the Yeamans.

"It has been overwhelming," Hamster said. "Julie has been overwhelmed, too. She cannot absorb it."

Yeaman said the Hub has overflowed with donations of clothing for all five members of the family.

"We don't really need anymore," she said. "All we need to buy is footwear."

Hard to remember

She admitted it's hard to remember everything the family lost in the fire.

"All we had was the clothes we were wearing," she said. She added they are now making lists of what was lost in the fire, going room by room through the house.

"You go shopping, and it's unreal what things cost," she said. "I feel so fabulous about the stuff people have given us."

One thing she does need, she added with a laugh, is "a pair of gray flannels, size 32."

Her husband lost his extensive collection of tools in the fire as well.

Building new house

The Yeamans will rebuild on the same property, with the house possibly done by May or early June. Until then, insurance will pay for them to live in a trailer which was to come to the property this week.

Until then, the family planned to live with the friends they've been with since the fire.

"I've learned a lot by watching how the community copes," Yeaman said. "People are so thoughtful and so organized and so sensible."

Ramsay, Almonte join forces to help build area's economy

By Ryland Coyne
Gazette editor

Home-based businesses, agricultural interests, downtown revitalization and industrial park development. It sounds like a strange mix. But all these issues and more now fall under the same umbrella now that Almonte and Ramsay Township's economic development committees have joined together.

Both communities' representatives had been meeting quarterly over the past two years to review areas of common interest. What they discovered was that they had so many common areas that they decided to join together.

"We seemed to gel really nicely," said Ramsay Deputy-Reeve Cliff Bennett. "I'm looking forward to it. It's quite new and quite exciting."

The two councils agreed with the merger proposal during meetings last month, giving a green light to the terms of reference agreed upon during previous sessions.

The committee's agenda can be summed up in its statement of intent.

"Whereas the Town of Almonte and the Township of Ramsay are naturally interdependent sharing many interests, values and goals developed within the context of a common history, culture and commerce,

Therefore be it resolved that the Corporation of the Town of Almonte and the Township of Ramsay agree to a productive collaboration in

economic development through cooperation, coordination and combined actions of mutual benefit."

Bennett said the committee was to meet for the first time this week.

"Alex (Almonte councillor Alex Gillis) and I met (in December) to look at how we might proceed," he said. "Something to be done Wednesday night is to establish overall priorities."

The eight-person committee will have four representatives from each municipality, with at least two being council members. The committee will report to each council and make recommendations. The chair must be a councillor and will alternate on an annual basis between Ramsay and Almonte.

Bennett said of the committee's 12 operating responsibilities, he'd like to see three or four "do-able projects" completed through the first year.

He pointed to the committee's role as "liaison" between like-minded organizations such as the Business Improvement Association, Chamber of Commerce or county tourism association as one of the key functions.

"That's one of our prime goals," he said.

As for an issue specific to Ramsay, Bennett said he will continue to work to enhance home-based businesses in the township.

In addition to the joint venture, Almonte council also dissolved the town's short-lived industrial commission.

New Year's baby in Almonte born to area couple

By Gena Gibson
Canadian reporter

Hannah Katherine Barrie arrived Jan. 2 at the Almonte General Hospital with much more difficulty than her two-year-old sister Samantha.

"Last time I was frozen (with an epidural)," explained Hannah and Samantha's mother, Cathy. "This time, I felt everything."

Hannah also arrived a week later than the expected due date, giving Cathy and her husband Paul the first New Year's baby in Carleton Place and Almonte. The seven pound, 12 ounce little girl was born at 3:50 p.m. Jan. 2.

For their perfect timing, the family received a cradle built by Karl Grosskleg along with a hand-knit blanket from Judy Grosskleg through the Almonte hospital, as well as a package of gifts from Sharon Shea of Carleton Place's Welcome Wagon.

"I wasn't expecting anything," Cathy admitted.

Paul and Cathy just moved to Carleton Place from Ottawa nine months ago, even though Paul still works in Ottawa for Nestle.

"He works in the frozen ice cream division," Cathy said after Paul left the hospital. "I wasn't craving ice cream at all, and I could get it for free."

Seriously, she said she and her

Hannah Katherine Barrie entered world at 3:50 p.m. Jan. 2

husband left their east-Ottawa home because "it was getting quite crime-infested."

"When you see the SWAT team going across your lawn, it's time to move," she said.

Cathy stressed they love Carleton Place and what it has to offer. "The people are so friendly," she said.

The Barries chose Carleton Place because it's nestled neatly between each of their families.

"His family is in Perth, mine's in Ottawa," she said. "It's the perfect spot."

Although Cathy said she found the whole childbirth experience painful, the nursing staff helped her through the six hours of labour.

Still, that doesn't mean she plans to rush right back into pregnancy again.

"With no epidural, it'll be a while," she admitted.

"This could be it," Paul agreed.

"I'd still like my boy," Cathy said. "But after this experience, I think I'll wait a while."



Newborn Hannah Katherine Barrie takes a rest in her new crib as parents Paul and Cathy watch over her. Hannah was the New Year's baby at Almonte General Hospital. Photo by Gena Gibson